

# MASTER BUILDER

In just eight years, Asish Mohapatra and his team have not only forged a flourishing category leader but also gave life to not one, but two unicorns. Now, this sector-aware operator is preparing to face the public markets

By **Binu Paul** • PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

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► **ON A VIBRANT** Mumbai night in early 2015, Asish Mohapatra and his companion Bhuvan Gupta were immersed in a conversation that crackled with energy. That would set the stage for something extraordinary. Amidst the lively banter, Mohapatra opened up about his dream of launching a B2B venture, extending an intriguing invitation to Gupta. Without a moment's hesitation, Gupta, then poised to become the Chief Technology Officer at the flourishing Snapdeal, nonchalantly shrugged and said: "Sure." Little did they fathom that that spontaneous exchange would chart the course of their future in unforeseen ways.

"I don't know if he agreed because he was tipsy. I'm not even sure if he heard the word B2B," muses Mohapatra, winner of the *BT-PwC India's Best CEOs* award in the Unicorn category. However, beneath the laughter, a deeper bond of mutual trust anchored the connection between Mohapatra and Gupta. Mohapatra emphasises that he would have readily reciprocated had Gupta been the one extending the invitation. Thus, fortified by this unspoken pact, Mohapatra assembled a dream team comprising Ruchi Kalra (Mohapatra's wife), Vasant Sridhar, Gupta, and Nitin Jain. United by trust, they embarked on a collective mission to forge a path in B2B for small and medium enterprises (SMEs).

The decision involved significant personal risks as both Mohapatra and Kalra left their respective jobs—Mohapatra as an investor at Matrix Partners and Kalra as a Partner at McKinsey & Company. They relocated from Mumbai to Delhi, with their new-born baby in tow, to set up the business.

Why B2B? Mohapatra's thesis was simple. In his line of work as a non-tech VC focussing on healthcare, consumer goods and manufacturing, he saw an uptick in B2B pitches from late 2014 through 2015. He was quite familiar with most of the solutions being built and felt many of them did not understand the sector well. He also saw a lot of qualified people—people with good pedigree and work experience—going into that sector. Above all, it marked a crucial and necessary career expansion for him as he was advised to explore technology investments for career growth, and he decided to take on the challenge himself, acknowledging the learning curve it would entail.

Right out of the gate, the team laid down five principles as the foundation of the company. They aimed to "help underserved SMEs, extend beyond just lending, ensure meticulous collections, fuel growth through debt, and maintain profitability." And they stuck with it.



**Of Business's primary aim when it began was to help underserved SMEs, extend beyond just lending, ensure meticulous collections, fuel growth through debt, and maintain profitability**